MERCY'S ANATOMY

Document MA-009: Script Format Standard

Canon Lock v2.3. Builds on MA-001 §3 and §11 and MA-002 §5

STATUS: LOCKED IN. The standard episode script is **58 pages** (allowed range 55-62), structured as **Cold Open + 5 Acts + Tag (7 segments)**, with **46 scenes** (allowed range 40-52). That fits a 43-minute one-hour network drama at roughly one page per minute, adjusted for this show's fast, overlapping, dialogue-heavy style.

1. Why These Numbers

- **Pages:** one script page is about one minute of screen time. A 43-minute episode would suggest 43 pages, but a fast-talking ensemble medical drama runs long on the page: walk-and-talks, overlapping banter, rapid OR dialogue and voiceover. Hour dramas in this style typically land in the mid-to-high 50s. **58 pages** gives room for the voiceover bookends without padding.
- **Acts:** MA-001 locked a **Cold Open + 5 acts + Tag**, which is the 2005 broadcast pattern of six commercial breaks. Every act ends on a hook strong enough to carry an audience through a break.
- **Scenes:** a medical ensemble cuts constantly between six interns, residents, attendings and four or five patient stories. At about 1.25 pages per scene, **46 scenes** keeps the pace urgent while still letting the big scenes (the surgery, the confession, the crash-out) breathe.

2. The Standard Episode Blueprint

Segment	Pages	Scenes	Purpose (MA-002 §5 episode engine)	Ends on
Cold Open	4	5	Opening voiceover, morning arrival, the inciting case	A hook before the main titles
Act One	11	9	The case assignment fight; personal arcs set up	First complication
Act Two	11	9	Diagnosis with an attending; patient bond forms; the case mirrors a doctor's struggle	A reversal
Act Three	11	8	The surgery at the center of the episode; OR conflict	The midpoint crisis (the biggest hook)
Act Four	10	8	Fallout; personal and professional lives collide	The lowest point or a bombshell
Act Five	9	5	The standalone case resolves; serialized arcs move forward	An emotional landing

Segment	Pages	Scenes	Purpose (MA-002 §5 episode engine)	Ends on
Tag	2	2	Closing voiceover; the final personal image	A last twist or a quiet button
TOTAL	**58**	**46**		

Main titles follow the Cold Open. Mercy's Anatomy uses a short title card (about 10 seconds) rather than a long opening sequence, which is 2005 network standard.

3. Targets by Episode Type

Episode type	Runtime	Pages	Acts	Scenes
Standard episode	~43 min	58 (55-62)	Cold Open + 5 + Tag	46 (40-52)
Super-sized episode	~60-65 min	78-85	Cold Open + 6 + Tag	60-66
Two-hour premiere or finale	~86 min	110-118	Cold Open + 10 + Tag (two linked hours)	88-96
Two-part event (aired as two episodes)	2 x 43 min	58 per part	Standard in each part	46 per part
Bottle or single-location episode	~43 min	56-60	Cold Open + 5 + Tag	28-36 (fewer, longer scenes)
Mass-casualty or disaster episode	~43 min	60-62	Cold Open + 5 + Tag	50-56 (more, faster scenes)

4. Formatting Rules

- Courier 12 pt; US Letter; standard screenplay margins (1.5" left, 1" right, top and bottom). Character cues at about 3.7", dialogue at about 2.5", parentheticals at about 3.1".
- **Every scene heading carries the date and time** (MA-001 §8): *INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - THE PIT - DAY*, then on the next line *FRIDAY, JULY 1, 2005, 6:12 AM*.
- Voiceover is marked *MARC-ANTHONY (V.O.)*, or the narrating season regular (MA-002 §3). The opening voiceover is about half a page; the closing voiceover is about a third of a page to half a page.
- **Scene numbers** run 1 to 46 per episode. Act breaks are marked *END OF ACT ONE* (and so on) and centered.
- The title page lists the episode number (for example, 1x01), the title, the narrator, the first and last in-story dates, and the canon documents it depends on.

5. Media Inserts (Articles, Social Media, Internet)

- The story is also told through news articles, headlines, social media and the internet (MA-001 §7). Each episode gets **4-8 media items**.
- On-screen media, such as a newspaper someone is reading, a TV news report, an AIM window or a blog post on a laptop, appears in the script as an **INSERT** and counts toward the 58 pages.

- Off-screen media (the world reacting between scenes) goes in a separate **Media Companion** section at the back of each episode PDF. It is dated and timed like scenes, and it does **not** count toward page length.
- All media follows the 2005-accurate rulebook in MA-001 §7, updated year by year as the series moves forward.

6. Episode PDF Package

Part	Contents
1. Title page	Episode code, title, narrator, in-story date range, cast list with each character's age on the episode's dates
2. Script	Cold Open + 5 Acts + Tag. 58 pages, 46 scenes.
3. Media Companion	4-8 dated news, social media and internet items
4. Continuity Sheet	New canon facts, the Knowledge Tracker update (who learned what), and the patient registry entries

7. Canon Log Additions

ID	Established fact	Source
C-056	Standard script: 58 pages (55-62), Cold Open + 5 Acts + Tag, 46 scenes (40-52).	MA-009
C-057	Every episode PDF has four parts: title page, script, Media Companion and Continuity Sheet.	MA-009 §6
C-058	On-screen media is written as INSERTs inside the page count. Off-screen media goes in the Media Companion, outside it.	MA-009 §5

END OF MA-009. CANON LOCKED (v2.3). 58 pages, 7 segments, 46 scenes.